Passives of causatives and perception verbs in Italian*

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Abstract

This paper argues for a phase-based analysis of passivization patterns with causative (*fare* 'make') and perception verbs (*vedere* 'see', *guardare* 'watch') in standard Italian, based on corpus data and acceptability judgements. We show that Italian (long) passives face clear restrictions sensitive to complement type and matrix verb, and argue that, as in English and Brazilian Portuguese, passivation is blocked where a causative/perception verb selects a (VoiceP) phase (Sheehan and Cyrino 2024). Conversely, long passivation is possible where a complement is either: (a) smaller than a phase (VP or vP) or (b) as large as TP, including a low 'subject position' feeding onwards A-movement.

Keywords: phase; phase impenetrability condition; A-movement; movement restrictions; complementation; complement size

1 Introduction

Passives of causative and perception verbs are restricted in various ways in many Germanic (e.g. English, German, Dutch and Danish) and Romance varieties (see Kayne 1975, Higginbotham 1983, Mittwoch 1990, Felser 1999, and many others). In English, for example, causatives allow passivization only where *to* is present in their complement, as in (1c) (see Higginbotham 1983):

(1) a. I **made/saw/heard/let/had/watched** [Peter read the book].

b. *Peter$_i$ was **made/had/let/seen/heard/watched** [t$_i$ read the book]

c. Peter$_i$ was **made/seen/heard/*let/*had/*watched** [t$_i$ to read the book]

In Romance languages, passivization is often blocked with (a subset of) causative/perception verbs followed by reduced clausal complements, or it is reported to be marginal or restricted (see Kayne 1975, 2010 on French; Cano Aguilar 1977, Treviño 1993, Torrego 1998, Tubino-Blanco 2010, Casalicchio and Herbeck 2024 on Spanish; Raposo 1981, Gonçalves 1999, Hornstein, Martins and Nunes 2010 on European Portuguese; Alsina 1996 on Catalan; Sheehan and Cyrino 2018, 2024 on Brazilian Portuguese). For example, in French, some speakers (particularly Canadians) marginally allow passivization of perception verbs, but not of causatives (see Kayne 1975, 2010, Miller and Lowrey 2003, Rowlett 2007, but cf. Pollock 1994, Veland 1998):

(2) Elle a été {%vue % entendue/*laissé(e)/*fait(e)} chanter cette chanson

she has been seen heard/ let made sing.INF this song

'She was seen/heard to sing this song.'

Only masculine singular arguments can ever be promoted in French passives of causatives (Bouvier 2001, Rowlett 2007). It has been claimed that this may be due to the fact that the participles *fait* 'made'/*laissé* 'let' do not inflect for gender/number in this context (see Bouvier 2001, Kayne 2010 amongst others).

Amongst Romance languages, Italian stands out for being more accepting of passivization (see Radford 1977, Burzio 1986, Guasti 1993, 2017, Cinque 2003, Kayne 2010). Despite this fact, there are also restrictions on Italian long passives, with differences across verbs (Guasti 1993). While *fare* 'make', *lasciare* 'let', *vedere* 'see' and *sentire* 'hear' all permit passivization when followed by the intransitive verb *dormire* 'sleep' (3a), other perception verbs like *guardare* 'watch' and *ascoltare* 'listen to' do not; in addition, according to the native intuitions of the first author, where the embedded verb is transitive *mangiare* 'eat', only *vedere* 'see' and *sentire* 'hear' permit promotion of the causee in a passive (3b):

(3) a. Anna è stata **fatta** / **lasciata** / **vista** / **sentita** / ***guardata** dormire.

Anna is been made let seen heard watched sleep.INF

'Anna was made/let/seen/heard to sleep.'

b. Anna è stata ***fatta** /***lasciata** /**vista** / **sentita** /***guardata** mangiare la mela.

Anna is been made let seen hear watched eat.INF the apple

'Anna was seen/heard eating the apple.'

Conversely, while it has been claimed that both *fare* 'make' and *lasciare* 'let' permit promotion of the embedded object in Italian long passives (see Burzio 1986, Guasti 1993, Kayne 2010), the same does not seem true of *vedere* (see Guasti 1993):

(4) La mela è stata **fatta** / **lasciata** / ***vista** mangiare al bambino (da Maria).

the apple is been made let seen eat.INF to.the child by Maria

'The apple has been made to be eaten by the child (by Maria).'

While some of these patterns can be attributed to differences in the behaviours of these verbs in the active, as we will show below, this is not always the case. As we note in Section 5.3, previous analyses of Italian long passives have relied on: (i) the relative height of causative/perception heads in a functional sequence (Cinque 2003), (ii) the functional/lexical status of causative verbs (Folli and Harley 2007), or (iii) the bundling together of Voice and v in Italian (Folli and Harley 2013). We show that the range of variation attested with the verbs *fare* 'make', *vedere* 'see' and *guardare* 'watch' raises challenges for all of these previous approaches and we propose a novel phase-based analysis which builds on and extends Sheehan and Cyrino's (2024) account of Brazilian Portuguese and English.

This paper provides an account of why passivization is sometimes, but not always, possible with Italian causative/perception verbs, integrating the Italian patterns into a broader cross-linguistic analysis. Section 2 provides the background on: (i) complementation patterns found with Italian causative and perception verbs in the active and (ii) previous empirical claims about Italian long passivization. Section 3 presents the results of a corpus study of Italian long passivization. Section 4 presents the results of a series of Acceptability Judgement Tasks (AJTs) on the same topic. In section 5, we present our analysis of the Italian patterns established in section 3-4, with additional AJT evidence supporting the predictions of this analysis, highlighting how our account differs from previous approaches. Finally, section 6 concludes and raises some issues for future research.

2 Background: complements of causative and perception verbs in Italian

This section surveys the main properties of causative and perception complementation in Italian, as previously discussed in the literature.

2.1 Clause Union and ECM complements in Italian and Romance

In many Romance languages (at least French, Italian, Spanish, European Portuguese, Catalan), causative and perception verbs can take (a subset of) three types of reduced, non-finite complements (see Kayne 1975, Skytte 1983, Burzio 1986, Salvi and Skytte 1991, Guasti 1993, 1996, Gonçalves 1999, Simone and Cerbasi 2001, Tubino-Blanco 2011, Ciutescu 2018, a.o.). Two of them involve Clause Union ('CU'), while the last involves Exceptional Case Marking ('ECM').[1]

Descriptively, the main difference is that, in CU, the matrix and the embedded verb form a single, verbal complex (5), so that only 'light' elements can intervene between the two verbs (e.g., some types of adverbs), whereas, in ECM contexts (6), a full DP can.

(5) Paola fa [dormire **i bambini**]. [CU]

Paola makes sleep.INF the children

'Paola makes the children sleep.'

(6) Paola guarda [**i bambini** dormire]. [ECM]

Paola watches the children sleep.INF

'Paola watches the children sleep.'

In addition, in CU only one argument is marked with accusative across both clauses: the internal argument of the infinitive, when the infinitive is transitive, or the causee, when the infinitive is intransitive or when no internal argument is present.[2] In CU contexts involving a transitive complement, the causee cannot therefore be accusative (7a), and so surfaces either as a dative (7b), or in a *by*-phrase (7c) (when overtly expressed). In the first case the construction is called *faire-inf* ('FI'), in the second *faire par* ('FP'), following Kayne's (1975) study of French (see also Lepschy 1976):

(7) a. *Paola fa leggere {il libro i bambini / i bambini il libro}.
Paola makes read.INF the book the children the children the book

b. Paola fa leggere {il libro ai bambini /ai bambini il libro}.
Paola makes read.INF the book to.the children to.the children the book

c. Paola fa leggere{il libro (dai bambini) /(dai bambini) il libro }.
Paola makes read.INF the book by.the children by.the children the book
'Paula makes the children read the book.'

Finally, in CU in Italian, all clitics must attach to the causative verb (8).

(8) Paola {**lo=** fa legger(e){=***lo**} {ai bambini / dai bambini}.
Paola 3MSG.ACC=makes read.INF=3MSG.ACC to.the children by.the children
'Paola makes the children read it.'

ECM displays a different pattern: object clitics thematically associated with the embedded verb must attach to it:

(9) Paola **li**= guarda legger=**lo**.
Paola 3MPL.ACC= watches read.INF=3MSG.ACC
'Paola watches them read it.'

To conclude this section, an observation about the distribution of these three constructions is necessary. In Romance, specific causative and perception verbs may select: (a) only CU, (b) only ECM, or (c) both CU and ECM. That is to say that in addition to selectional patterns with these verbs varying across Romance varieties, we also find variation across verbs within a single language. In this paper we will show that the variation is actually even greater than this because the same type of (CU/ECM) complement can have different syntactic properties in the same language depending on which verb selects it. We focus here on Italian to illustrate this variation, but we believe this to hold more widely across Romance varieties (see also Sheehan and Cyrino 2024).

2.2 Italian causative verbs

Italian has two main causative verbs, *fare* 'do, make' and *lasciare* 'let, allow'. The first is the unmarked causative, which is used when there is an obligation, but also when there is a generic process of 'causing' or 'permitting' someone to do something (or something to happen). In the last case, the verb *lasciare* is also used, especially when the causer permits someone to do something, or when she does not interfere with an ongoing event.

Fare only selects CU complements, of both the FI and the FP type. ECM complements are generally ruled out under *fare* (but see Burzio 1978 for some exceptional cases):

(10)	a. *Maria	**lo**=	fa	cantare	l'	Aida.	
	Maria	3MSG.ACC=	makes	sing.INF	the	Aida	
	b. *Maria	fa	**i**	**bambini**	cantare.		
	Maria	makes	the	children	sing		

The pattern with *lasciare* is less straightforward: CU complements are accepted by all speakers; ECMs are accepted by a minority of speakers (with regional variation), but acceptability improves when the causee is a clitic instead of a full DP. Because of these complexities, in this paper, we focus on *fare* as a causative verb. We take up the status of *lasciare* in other work (see Casalicchio and Sheehan, in prep.).

2.3 Italian perception verbs

Perception verbs can be divided into two groups: (i) verbs with a (non-agentive) experiencer subject where perception is involuntary (e.g. *see*, *hear*); (ii) verbs with an agentive subject where perception is deliberate (e.g. *watch*, *listen to*).[3] In this paper we focus on *vedere* 'see' and *guardare* 'watch' as representatives of these two groups.[4] *Vedere* 'see' can select both CU and ECM complements (11a), whereas *guardare* 'watch' can select only ECM complements (11b).

(11) a.

{**L'= / gli=**}	ho	visto	suonare	il	piano.
3MSG.ACC /3SG.DAT	have.1SG	seen	play.INF	the	piano

'I saw him play the piano.'

b.

{**Lo=/ *gli=**}	guardo	suonare	il	piano.
3MSG.ACC /3SG.DAT	watch.1SG	play.INF	the	piano

'I watch him play the piano.'

Table 1 resumes the selectional properties of these causative and perception verbs. As the table shows, *fare* and *guardare* show the opposite behaviour, while *vedere* (and, for some speakers, also *lasciare*) is compatible with all three complement types.

Table 1
Non-finite complements of Italian causative/perception verbs

	Faire-inf	*Faire par*	ECM

Fare	Y	Y	N
Lasciare	Y	Y	%
Vedere	Y	Y	Y
Guardare	N	N	Y

2.4 Passives of causative and perception verbs

Guasti (1993) discusses passives with *fare*, *vedere* and *sentire*, claiming that *fare* can be passivized in CU contexts with both FP and FI complements. The promoted argument is whichever argument would receive accusative case in the active: either the causee (with intransitive complements) or the object of the embedded infinitive (with transitives) (indicated here as a trace *t*).

In the case of *vedere*, Guasti does not discuss the full pattern, but she notes that the promotion of the internal argument from a FP complement in CUs is ungrammatical (12a), whereas the promotion of the perceivee (presumably an ECM) is fine (12b):

(12) a. * La macchina fu vista riparare *t* (da Ugo). (Guasti 1993:116)
the car was seen repair.INF by Ugo

b. Gianni è stato visto [*t* riparare la macchina]. (Guasti 1993:137)
Gianni is been seen repair.INF the car
'Gianni was seen to repair the car.'

Folli and Harley (2007) also discuss Italian passives, focusing on *fare*-causatives. Contrary to Guasti's claims, they propose that all instances of long passives involve FP and not FI complements, with two main pieces of evidence for this claim. First, they note that long passives are strongly marked/ungrammatical when the infinitive is what they call a "true unergative" verb; under their approach, this follows if the FI cannot passivize at all, because (according to them) unergatives can only occur in the FI, not in the FP (which embeds a VP complement lacking a projected external argument):

(13) *Marco è stato fatto telefonare (da Gianni). (Folli and Harley 2007:226)

Marco is been made telephone.INF (by Gianni)

Second, they note that the demoted causer in a long passive must be agentive, so that Maria is a potential demoted causer in (14), whereas *la rabbia* 'the rage' is not:

(14) È stato fatto rompere il tavolo (a Marco) {da Maria / *dalla rabbia}.

is been made break.INF the table (to Marco) {by Maria / *by.the rage}

'A table was made to break (on Marco) {by Maria /*by the rage}.'

(Folli and Harley 2007:234, their translation)

This appears to parallel a restriction seen with FP (but not with FI) in the active (as noted by Kayne 1975 for French and Burzio 1986 for Italian), whereby inanimate causers like *la rabbia* 'the rage' are blocked:

(15) La rabbia fece rompere il tavolo { a Gianni /*da Gianni}. (Burzio 1986:268)

the rage made break.INF the table to Gianni / by Gianni

'Rage made Gianni break the table.'

Folli and Harley further claim that *Marco* in (14) is not a true causee but rather a malefactive/benefactive, hence their translation of *a Marco* as 'on Marco'.

To summarize then, Guasti (1993) claims that *fare* 'make' generally permits passivization involving promotion of any argument which would be accusative in the active, whereas Folli and Harley (2007) claim that only long passives of FP are possible with *fare*. When it comes to *vedere* 'see', Guasti claims that this verb selects a larger ECM complement and for this reason only allows promotion of embedded 'subjects' (and not internal arguments) in long passives. This is somewhat surprising, though, as, in the active, *vedere* is clearly compatible with CU (as noted above). Finally, to the best of our knowledge, there has been no discussion of verbs such as *guardare*, but according to the intuitions of the first author, they appear to be incompatible with passivization altogether. In the following sections, we report the results of a corpus study and a series of acceptability judgement tasks which aim to evaluate these claims empirically and establish more clearly when Italian causative and perception verbs permit passivization.

3 Corpus study

To investigate the availability of long passives in Italian, we first carried out a corpus study in summer 2021. We used the freely-available online ItWac corpus and considered the causative verbs *fare* 'make' and *lasciare* 'let', and the perception verbs *vedere* 'see' and *guardare* 'watch' (see Appendix 1 for information on the corpus). We extracted all examples of long passives with 3rd person subjects where the verb was in the following tenses: present, simple past (*passato remoto*), perfect (*passato prossimo*) and future. After deleting false positives (e.g., cases in which *fare* was used as the lexical verb 'make, produce' and other extraneous cases), the raw number of examples collected amounted to 1,050. We checked all these examples manually (with the help of our summer intern Annapia Borraccino) tagging them according to morphosyntactic criteria (person/number/gender of promoted subject, presence of a *by* phrase, type of complement, grammatical status of the promoted argument).

3.1 Overall results

The results support Guasti's (1993) claim that passives of causative and perception verbs are subject to different distributions (see Table 2). Passives are attested with all types of promoted arguments, although in a majority of cases the embedded verb is unaccusative (i.e., the promoted argument is an internal argument base-generated as the complement of V – Burzio 1986).

Table 2
Arguments promoted in long passives

	External arguments		Internal arguments			
Promoted subject	Transitive subject	Unergative subject	Transitive object	Unaccusative subject	Unclear	**Total**
fare	0	58 (10%)	264 (47%)	236 (42%)	0	**558**
lasciare	2 (1%)	53 (19%)	12 (4%)	212 (76%)	0	**279**
vedere	54 (25%)	50 (24%)	2 (1%)	105 (50%)	1	**212**
guardare	0	0	0	1 (100%)	0	**1**
TOTAL	**56 (5%)**	**161 (15%)**	**278 (26%)**	**554 (53%)**	**1**	**1,050**

However, if we consider each verb individually, it becomes clear that the numbers are unevenly distributed: long passives of *fare* are overwhelmingly attested when the promoted argument is the internal argument of a transitive or unaccusative verb (almost 90% of occurrences), and unattested with external arguments of transitive verbs. *Lasciare* has a low number of occurrences with transitive verbs, while *vedere* is virtually unattested with promotion of a transitive object. Finally, we found just one occurrence of long passives with *guardare*. In the next subsections, we discuss each verb separately (except for *lasciare*, which shows a more complex pattern of inter-speaker variation that we take up elsewhere, see Casalicchio and Sheehan, in prep).

3.2 Passives with fare

Fare shows a clear preference for internal arguments to be promoted in long passives. Nonetheless, while passives of unergatives are much less frequent, they are clearly attested (*pace* Folli and Harley 2007). Long passives promoting the external argument of transitive verbs, however, never occur with *fare* in our corpus (see Table 2).

These results suggest that any argument receiving accusative case in the CU complement can be promoted to subject in the passive, irrespective of thematic role, as proposed by Guasti (1993). The subject of transitive verbs, on the other hand, never receives accusative case in active sentences (see § 2.2), and consequently its promotion in long passives is blocked.[5]

The following examples illustrate the promotion of internal arguments: an unaccusative subject (16) and a transitive object (17) respectively:

(16) L' aereo **è stato fatto atterrare** in una zona lontana dall' aerostazione.
the airplane is been made land.INF in a zone far from.the airport
'The aeroplane was made to land in a zone far from the airport.'

(17) … ma non mi= **è stata fatta pagare** alcuna tassa.

but not 1SG.DAT= is been made pay.INF any tax

Lit. '…but no tax was made pay by me.'

The case of unergatives is more intriguing, because Folli and Harley (2007) claim that "true unergatives" are ungrammatical in long passive constructions (see section 2.4), citing examples like (13) above, on whose unacceptability native speakers tend to agree.[6] Nonetheless, in our corpus we found 58 instances involving promotion of unergative subjects, for example:

(18) ..[i] pullman **sono stati fatti viaggiare**, come al solito, incolonnati a 70 km/h

the coaches are been made travel.INF like as normal queued.up at 70 km/h

'The coaches were made to travel just like normal, queued back-to-back at 70 km/h'

The verb *viaggiare* 'travel' is a typical unergative verb, as all unaccusativity tests show (see Appendix 2 for a full list of all the unergative verbs found in the corpus). The corpus results therefore show that unergatives are grammatical in long passives of *fare* (at least for some speakers), despite the unacceptability of examples like (13). Clearly there is more than one class of unergative verbs. We return to this issue in section 4.

3.3 Long passives of the perception verbs vedere *and* guardare

The pattern emerging from the two perception verbs investigated is completely different (cf. Table 3). With *vedere*, all kinds of subjects can be promoted, while the objects of transitive verbs are virtually unattested. *Guardare* is again different, because our corpus contains just one relevant passive example (with the infinitive *morire* 'die'). We might therefore assume that long passives of *guardare* 'watch' are indeed ungrammatical for Italian speakers (see Table 2).

Consider first *vedere*. With intransitive verbs, passives are well attested with unaccusative, unergative verbs and transitive verbs. Passives of intransitive verbs are, of course, ambiguous, because they could be passives of either CUs or ECMs. There are, however, 40 examples that show attachment of the clitic *si* to the infinitive, a distinctive property of ECM complements, indicating that long passives of ECMs are possible (cf. section 2.1):

(19) Convogli di blindati USA sono stati visti diriger=**si** verso la zona.
convoys of tanks USA are been seen head.INF=SI towards the zone
'Armed US convoys were seen to head towards the zone.'

On the other hand, our corpus contains no case of clitic attachment to the higher verb in long passives of *vedere* (which is one diagnostic for CU), suggesting that long passives of CU under *vedere* may not be possible.

In the case of transitive verbs, the pattern is the reverse of that found with *fare*: with *vedere*, promotion of transitive subjects is widely attested, while there are just two apparent occurrences of promoted transitive objects. Their scarcity suggests them to be unacceptable or at least highly marginal in the language.

To sum up the behaviour of *vedere*, long passives are possible as long as the promoted argument is base generated as a subject. This is compatible, in principle, with the interpretation of these examples as passives of ECMs. The corpus does not give us any clear evidence for the grammaticality of long passives of CU; though, of course, this could be an accidental gap in the data.

Overall, the patterns of long passivization in the corpus study suggest that (i) *fare* permits long passives of CU complements but with restrictions on promotion of the subjects of unergative verbs (ii) *vedere* allows long passives only of ECM complements and *guardare* does not permit long passives.

Table 3
The grammaticality of passives with the three verbs

	Fare	*vedere*	*guardare*
ECM		Y	N
CU	Y	(?)	

Table 3 summarises the results of the corpus study. The implication is that passivization is compatible with both ECM and CU, but some important questions arise.

(i) Why is passivization of *fare* possible with only some unergative verbs?

(ii) Does *vedere* permit long passives with CU, and, if not, why not?

(iii) Are passives of *guardare* ungrammatical, and if so why, given that *vedere* permits long passivation with ECM complements?

Section 4 describes a series of AJTs that we carried out in order to verify whether the patterns that emerged in the corpus are confirmed by speaker intuitions. In addition, we use the AJTs to assess the three questions posed above. For example, for *vedere* we use additional tests to distinguish between long passives of ECM and CU and establish whether the latter are ever grammatical, and we test the acceptability of long passives with different classes of unergatives to identify what regulates acceptability.

4 Acceptability judgement task

Building on the results of the corpus study, we ran a series of online acceptability judgement tasks between December 2021 and February 2023. For details of the methodology and demographic, see Online Appendix 3. Both the mean (M) and median (Mdn) are given for individual examples in the following discussion.[7]

4.1 Results: basic passivization patterns

4.1.1 Fare *'make'*

With *fare*, the AJTs confirm that promotion of unaccusative subjects (20) and transitive objects (21) is acceptable, as suggested by the corpus study:

(20) (?)Il gatto non **è stato fatto uscire** stamattina. (M: **3.88**, Mdn: 4)
the cat not is been made go.out.INF this.morning
lit. 'The cat wasn't made to go out this morning.'

(21) La vecchia chiesa **è stata fatta demolire** dal comune. (M: **4.64**, Mdn: 5)
the old church is been made demolish.INF by-the municipality
'The old church was demolished by the municipality.'

Some speakers rated (20) slightly lower than we might have expected, possibly because the causee is a cat, rather than a human.[8]

Promotion of transitive subjects (22) was uniformly rejected by respondents, as suggested by the absence in the corpus of such examples (M: **1.21**, Mdn: 1):

(22) *I bambini **sono stati fatti dire** le preghiere dal catechista.

the children are been made say.INF the prayers by.the catechist

The results for unergative verbs were more variable. In total, we tested examples with nine unergative verbs and there was considerable variation across examples. The following example with *giocare* (‘play’) was widely rejected:

(23) *No, Giada **è stata fatta giocare** dalla tata. (M: **1.8**, Mdn: **1**)

no Giada is been made play.INF by.the nanny

Two examples were also included with the verb *pensare* ‘think’, an unergative verb which selects for a PP complement. Both were rated to be strongly unacceptable.

(24) *Gianni {ci=} **è stato fatto pensar** {=ci} a lungo

Gianni LOC.CL= is been made think.INF =LOC.CL a lot

prima di rispondere all' ultima domanda. (M: **1.4/1.2**, Mdn: **1**)

before of answer to-the last question

These examples were intended to test the compatibility of long passivization with clitic climbing but both minimal pairs were strongly rejected, suggesting that *pensare* ‘think’ is simply incompatible with long passivization. Other examples with unergative verbs, which were modelled on examples found in our corpus, were rated much higher:

(25) I computer dell’ assessorato **sono stati** (M: **4.16**, Mdn: **4.5**)

the computers of-the council.department are been

fatti lavorare al di sotto delle loro potenzialità.

made work.INF at below of-the their potentialities

'The council department's computers were made to work below their capabilities.'

(26) è come un pilota che **è stato fatto correre** senza casco. (M: **4.22**, Mdn: **5**)

is like a pilot that is been made race.INF without helmet

'[Our party's candidate] is like a pilot that was sent to race without a helmet.'

This split in the behaviour of unergative verbs has, as we have already remarked, been hinted at previously in the literature. While Folli and Harley(2007) claim that long passivization of *fare* is not possible with unergative verbs (see section 2.4), they also acknowledge that some unergative verbs seem to be more compatible with long passivization than others (e.g. *lavorare* 'work'). Unsurprisingly, Guasti cites verbs of this type when claiming that long passives of unergatives are fully grammatical.

Folli and Harley cite unergative verbs like *tossire* 'cough', *tremare* 'tremble', *ridere* 'laugh' and *piangere* 'cry', which are incompatible with passives under *fare*; they all usually describe involuntary actions, and in the passive, as noted in Section 2.4, the demoted causer needs to be agentive. This might explain the unacceptability of these verbs in passives, though coercive agentive readings should also be possible. Moreover, this explanation does not extend to verbs like *telefonare* 'telephone' and *giocare* 'play', which are clearly agentive but which were also rated unacceptable in long passives in our AJT. As noted in section 3, we found long passives with 40 different unergative verbs in our corpus study (see Appendix 2). A consideration of the attested corpus examples leads us to posit the following hypothesis:

(27) **Unergative hypothesis**: Bivalent unergatives which can select for a PP complement are incompatible with long passivization under *fare*.

Although verbs like *pensare* 'think', *giocare* 'play', *ridere* 'laugh' and *telefonare* 'phone' are unergative, these verbs freely surface with PP complements and so can be considered optionally bivalent at the thematic level: [9]

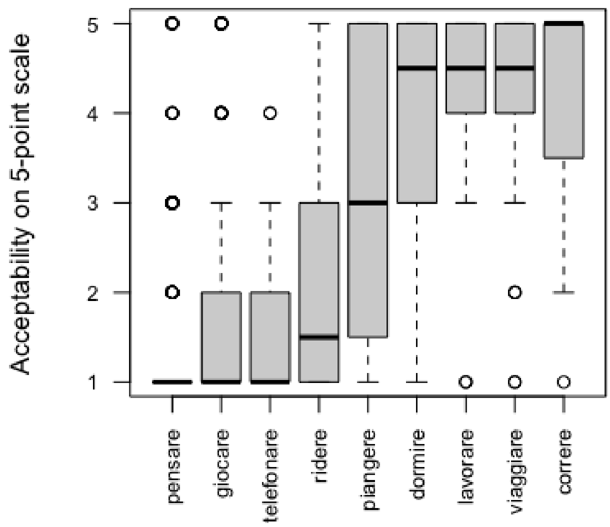
(28) Giochiamo [a carte]?
play.1PL at cards
'What about playing cards?'

(29) Non ridere [di loro].
not laugh.INF of them
'Don't laugh at them!'

In fact, example (24) shows that *pensare* resists long passivization also where it takes a PP complement (which is cliticized through the clitic pronoun *ci* in these examples). Our hypothesis was that, for this reason, these unergatives would pattern with transitive verbs when it comes to long passives, disallowing promotion of the external argument. In contrast, verbs like *piangere* 'cry', *correre* 'race', *dormire* 'sleep', *lavorare* 'work' and *viaggiare* 'travel' are more robustly monovalent and do not combine with a PP complement. These verbs are expected to be more accepting of long passivization.

The patterns of acceptability of these verbs in Figure 1 (generated using R – R Core Team 2018) are largely as predicted:[10] monovalent unergative verbs (*correre* 'race', *lavorare* 'work', *viaggiare* 'travel', and *dormire* 'sleep') tend to be rated acceptable in a long passivization context, whereas bivalent unergative verbs (*pensare* ‘think’, *giocare* ‘play’, *ridere* ‘laugh’, and *telefonare* ‘telephone’) tend to be unacceptable. [11] One verb, *piangere* ‘cry’ behaved unexpectedly, however, and was more variable in its behaviour, with median acceptability of 3 and an interquartile range covering most of the five-point scale.[12]

Figure 1: Long passives under *fare* with unergative complements



(30) La piccola Lidia è stata fatta piangere da sua sorella. (M: 3.17, Mnd: 3)
the little Lidia is been made cry.INF by her sister
‘Lidia was made to cry by her sister.’

A pairwise comparison of the acceptability of long passives of these verbs (using the emmeans package of R – Lenth 2025) shows that *pensare* ‘think’, *giocare* ‘play’, *ridere* ‘laugh’ and *telefonare* ‘telephone’ pattern alike and differently from all other verbs (p=<.0001). Note that this is true even though *pensare* ‘think’ and *telefonare* ‘telephone’ were presented with a PP complement unlike *giocare* ‘play’ and *ridere* ‘laugh’. *Piangere* ‘cry’ patterns only with *dormire* ‘sleep’, which is also quite variable in its behaviour but clearly permits long passivization.[13] Finally, *correre* 'race', *lavorare* 'work' and *viaggiare* all pattern alike.[14]

The variable acceptability of *piangere* 'cry' is surprising. It must be noted, however, that *piangere* can combine with a PP, though it is not clear whether this is a complement or an adjunct (42a). In addition, in literary (especially poetic) Italian, *piangere* is used transitively (with a meaning similar to 'mourn'):[15]

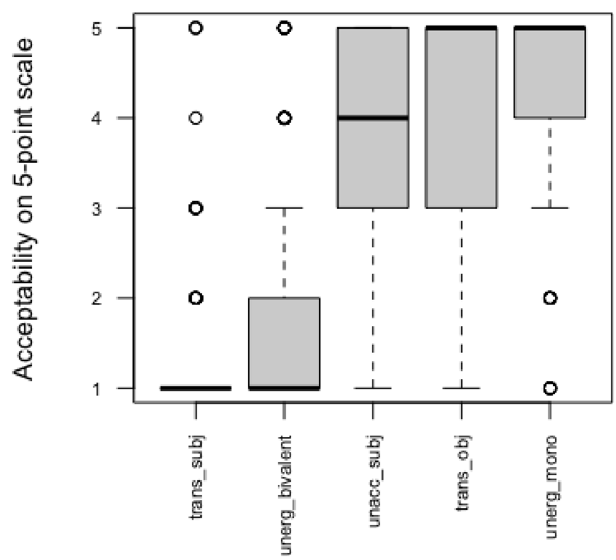
(31) a. Anche il cielo piange per noi!
also the heaven cries for us
'Even heaven is crying for us!'

b. Lo= piansero per sette giorni.
3MSG.ACC= cried for seven days
'They mourned him for seven days.'

It is therefore possible that some speakers construe *piangere* as a bivalent verb and others construe it as monovalent, leading to significant interspeaker variation.[16]

If we categorise unergative verbs according to valency (omitting *piangere* 'cry' and *pensarci* 'think', using comparison of regression models via the Anova function in R), we see a statistically significant effect of valency on the acceptability of long passives of *fare* causatives ($F(2,696)= 256.31$, $p<0.0001$). Moreover, there is no statistical difference between monovalent unergatives and either unaccusatives or transitive objects ($p=1$): these examples pattern alike and unlike transitive ($p<.0001$) and bivalent unergative examples ($p<.0001$). Surprisingly, though, transitive subjects still behave differently from bivalent unergatives (p=0.0003), with the latter being more acceptable than the former for some speakers.

Figure 2: Long passives under *fare:* monovalent and bivalent unergatives[17]



These results explain the relative scarcity of long passives promoting an unergative subject with *fare*: there is an additional restriction blocking passives of all bivalent verbs (transitive and unergative). We discuss this effect further in section 5.

Overall, then, our AJT supports the claim that *fare* allows long passivization of all arguments which receive accusative case in the active, with the added restriction that bivalent verbs resist long passivization. For a consideration of social factors, see Appendix 5, which shows that these passives are more acceptable for speakers from the centre, north and Sardinia and for highly educated speakers from Sicily and the south.

4.1.2 Guardare *'watch'*

The AJT data support the claim that *guardare* cannot undergo long passivization. This is true regardless of the site of base generation of the promoted argument as an external or internal argument: we tested unaccusatives, unergatives and transitive verbs with promotion of the subject and of the object. All but one example received a median acceptability of 1; however, long passives promoting a transitive subject were rated slightly higher, with a median of 2 (32-33).

(32) *L' attrice **è stata guardata uscire** dai paparazzi (M: **1.5**, Mdn: **1**)

the actress is been watched go.out.INF by-the paparazzi

(33) *Luigi **è stato guardato digitare** il pin da un malvivente. (M: **2.3**, Mdn: **2**)

Luigi is been watched digit.INF the pin by a criminal

We can therefore conclude that long passives of *guardare* 'watch' are not grammatical in standard Italian.

4.1.3 Vedere *'see'*

Guardare contrasts with *fare* but also *vedere* 'see', which for our AJT respondents permits long passives with promotion of unaccusative, unergative and transitive subjects (34), but not transitive objects (35), again paralleling the corpus study.[18]

(34) (?)Gianni **è stato visto rubare** una macchina da un poliziotto.(M: **3.61**, Mdn: **4**)

Gianni is been seen steal.INF a car by a policeman

'Gianni was seen stealing a car by a policeman.'

(35) a. *La tabaccheria **è stata vista rapinare** da due malviventi. (M: **1.57**, Mdn: **1**)

the tobacco.shop is been seen rob.INF by two criminals

b. *Stanotte un uomo **è stato visto derubare** a Paolo. (M: **1.32**, Mdn: **1**)

tonight a man is been seen rob.INF to Paolo

The slightly marked acceptability of examples like (34) shows that long passivization is compatible with transitive ECM complements. By considering clitic placement, we can test whether long passivization with intransitive verbs is also compatible with CU or not. The contrast in (36) suggests an incompatibility: when the clitic remains on the embedded verb (indicating ECM), the sentence is judged acceptable, whereas the sentences with clitic climbing (indicating CU) are rejected:

(36) Gianni {***ci=**} **è stato visto andar{=ci}** spesso. (CU; M: **2.3**, Mdn: **2**)

Gianni there= is been seen go.INF=there often (ECM; M: **4.07**, Mdn: **4**)

'Gianni has often been seen to go there.'

The AJT data for *vedere* are, again, in line with the corpus study. Only external arguments are possible in long passives suggesting that *vedere* can only be passivized where it takes an ECM complement. Considering also sociolinguistic variables, we find no effect of age, gender, or region, but we do find an effect of education parallel to that found with *fare* (see Appendix 5 for details).

4.2 Interim conclusions

The AJT results align very closely with the results of the corpus study:

i. Long passives of *guardare* are not possible.

ii. Long passives of *fare* CU complements are possible, promoting objects or the subjects of monovalent verbs.

iii. Long passives of *vedere* are possible only with ECM and not CU complements.

In the next section, we propose an analysis of these patterns, providing further empirical evidence (also from the AJTs) to support our proposal.

5 Towards an analysis of Italian

In this section, we seek to explain the very different behaviours of *fare, guardare* and *vedere*, more specifically:

a. Why does *vedere* but not *guardare* allow passives of ECM complements?

b. Why does *fare* but not *vedere* allow long passives of CU complements?

Our hypotheses are as follows:

i. **In ECM**, the complement of *vedere* is always larger than the complement of *guardare*, including a tense projection and a low subject position. This serves to facilitate 'long' passivization from an embedded clause.

ii. **In CU**, the complement of *vedere* is always larger than the complement of *fare*, including an obligatorily projected perceivee and a Voice projection. This serves to block long passivization.

Our analysis builds on Sheehan and Cyrino's (2018, 2024) account of English and Brazilian Portuguese long passives. They make the case that the complements in (1a-b), repeated here as (37a-b), are VoiceP phases, whereas those in (1c)/(37c) are TPs with an embedded subject position.[19]

(37) a. I **made/saw/heard/let/had/watched** [$_{\text{VoiceP}}$ Peter read the book].

b. *Peter$_i$ was **made/had/let/seen/heard/watched** [$_{\text{VoiceP}}$ t$_i$ read the book]

c. Peter$_i$ was **made/seen/heard/*let/*had/*watched** [$_{\text{TP}}$ t$_i$ to read the book]

The descriptive generalisation they propose is that long passivization is possible from TP complements but not VoiceP complements in English.[20] Considering also the patterns of long passivization in Brazilian Portuguese, they further argue that the verbs *mandar* ‘have’ and *deixar* ‘let’ take an ECM complement which projects TP, and for this reason long passives are possible. With the verb *ver* ‘see’, ECM complements are smaller VoicePs blocking long passivization. However, *ver* ‘see’ can also take a non-phasal VP lacking an external argument in which case long passives become possible. This, they claim, explains why any subject can be promoted with *mandar/deixar* whereas only the subjects of unaccusatives can be promoted under *ver,* as illustrated by (38)-(39):

(38) Os meninos foram {*feitos/ *vistos/ mandados/ deixados} comer (a sopa).
the boys were made seen had let eat (the soup)
Lit. ‘The boys were had/let (to) eat (the soup).’

(39) Os meninos foram {*feitos/ vistos/ mandados/deixados} sair.
the boys were made seen had let leave
Lit. ‘The boys were had/let (to) leave.’

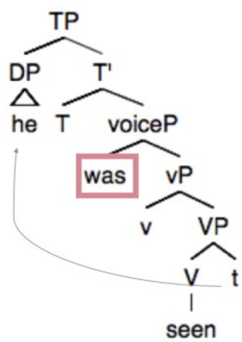
To explain this effect, Sheehan and Cyrino (2018, 2024) claim that long passivization of VoiceP complements is blocked by a version of the Phase Impenetrability Condition (PIC 2) with delayed transfer:

(40) PIC 2 (Chomsky 2001)

[Given structure [ZP Z ... [HP α [H YP]]], with H and Z the heads of phases]: The domain of H is not accessible to operations at ZP; only H and its edge are accessible to such operations.

As they show, one main corollary of PIC2 is that local A-movement does not need to transit through the phase edge because transfer of vP is delayed until C is merged.

Figure 3. Local A-movement under PIC2



Sheehan and Cyrino's (2018, 2024) proposal is simply that where the complement of *make/see/hear/have/let* is phasal, by the time matrix T probes, arguments contained in the complements of these causative/perception verbs are no longer visible because of PIC2 (Fig. 4). In essence, A-dependencies can cross only one phase head, assuming A-movement cannot use phase edges as escape hatches.

Figure 4. PIC2 and long passivization

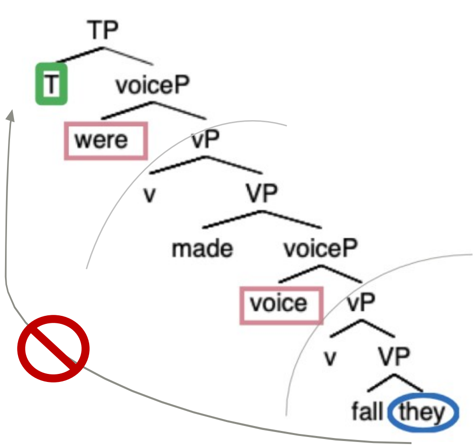
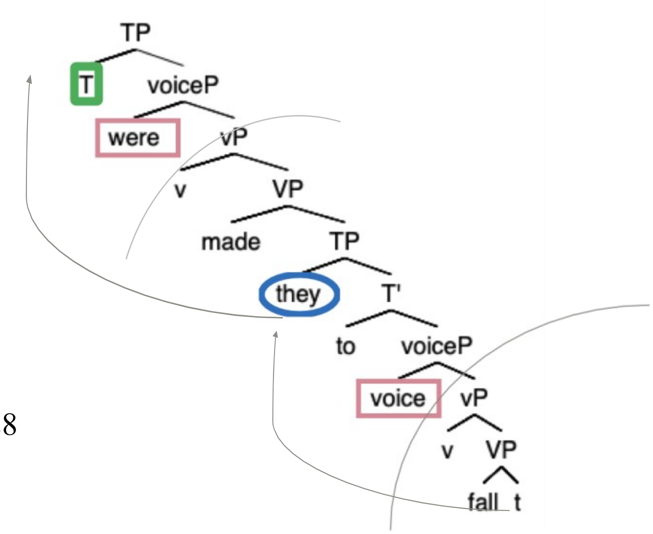


Figure 5. To-infs feed long passivization



According to Sheehan and Cyrino, however, English *to infinitives* are TPs with an EPP feature creating a lower subject position. Here embedded T attracts the highest argument from inside VoiceP and this additional obligatory A-movement serves to make this argument accessible to matrix T, feeding successive cyclic A-movement (Fig 5). They claim that causative/perception verbs tend to select phasal complements – probably because they select semantically for events (Rosen 1990), so long passivization is often banned with these verbs. The exception is where these verbs take either a TP complement with an additional EPP feature or where they take a smaller non-phasal complement.

With this proposal in mind, we now turn to the Italian data and argue that this approach can be extended to deal with the patterns described above. We leave a comparison of our approach with previous accounts to section 5.3, where we show that our analysis is able to address non-trivial issues with previous accounts, not least the intricate differences in passivization patterns across verbs.

5.1 ECM passives in Italian

Our basic proposal is that ECM complements come in different sizes in Italian, as is the case in English and Brazilian Portuguese. Whereas the ECM complements of *guardare* are VoicePs, the ECM complements of *vedere* are TPs. This would make the derivation in Italian long passives of *vedere* akin to that in English to-complements (Figure 5).[21] Conversely, with *guardare,* passivization is blocked, as it is with English bare verbal complements (Figure 4).

Crucially, there is strong independent evidence that the ECM complements of *vedere* are larger than the ECM complements of *guardare*. The complement of *vedere* permits future reference and can contain the modal *dovere* and the high adverb *sicuramente*, both of which we assume to be higher than the Voice domain (Cinque 1999, 2006). Minimal pairs in our online AJT strongly support a difference of this kind (41-43):

(41) Già ti {**vedo** / ***guardo**} passare l'esame con 30 e lode **domani**.
already you see.1SG watch.1SG pass.INF the-exam with 30 and honours tomorrow
'I can already see you passing the exam with honours tomorrow.'
(M: **4.58 vs. 1.43**; Mdn: **5 vs. 1**)

(42) [Dopo che è rimasta incinta] l' ho {**vista** / ***guardata**}
after that is remained pregnant 3FSG.ACC= have.1SG seen watched
dover rinunciare all' università. (M: **4.27 vs. 2.73**; Mdn: **5 vs. 2**)
must.INF give.up to-the university
'[After she got pregnant] I saw how she had to retire from university.'

(43) Questa fiera, l'abbiamo **{vista / *guardata}sicuramente** crescere negli anni.
this fair it-have1.PL seen watched surely grow.INF in-the years
'We have seen how this fair has surely grown in this years.'
(M: **4.55 vs. 2.37**; Mdn: **5 vs. 2**)

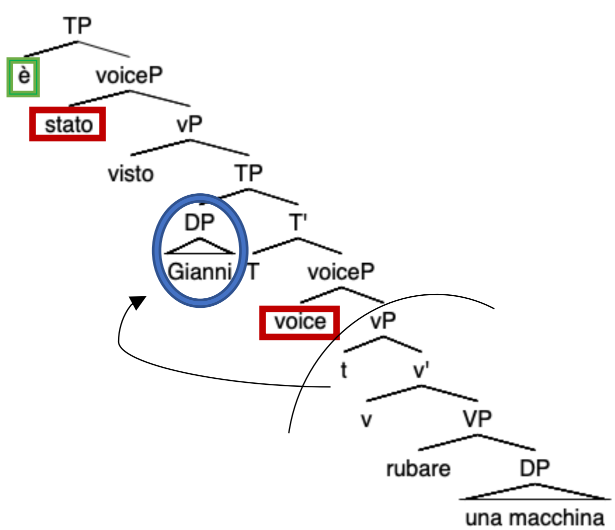
Furthermore, the complement both of agentive perception verbs like *guardare* and non-agentive verbs like *vedere* obligatorily contains *si*, which we take to be possible only in the presence of Voice, either because *si* realises or is licensed by Voice (Labelle 2008):

(44) L' ho **guardata** vestir=**si/*vestire**.

3SG.ACC- have.1SG watched dress-*se* dress

'I watched her get dressed.'

Figure 6: passive of non-agentive ECM complements in Italian[22]



The different behaviours of *vedere* vs. *guardare* when it comes to long passives with ECM complements therefore follow naturally from the fact that *vedere* selects for a TP complement (Figure 6) whereas *guardare* selects for a smaller (phasal) VoiceP.

5.2 Clause union passives

As noted in sections 2.2-2.3, in Italian CU complements are found with causative verbs (*fare* and *lasciare*) and with the two perception verbs *vedere* and *sentire*. As with ECM complements, however, we argue that CU complements are not always of the same size. More specifically, we propose that CU complements of *fare* are smaller than VoiceP: they are vPs when they are used in FI, VPs when they are used in FP. Crucially, both complement types are non-phasal. On the other hand, the perception verb *vedere* selects a phasal VoiceP, both with FIs and FPs. This pattern explains, we suggest, why only *fare* allows long passives (since it does not select a phasal complement). *Vedere,* on the other hand, always selects a complement larger than a phase and so allows passives only where these complements are TPs (in ECM contexts, as shown above in section 5.1).

5.2.1 The different size of CU complements of fare *and* vedere

Various pieces of evidence show that *fare* always takes a complement that is smaller than a VoiceP, while *vedere* takes a (phasal) VoiceP. The first comes from the distribution of *si*, which we assume to be possible only in the presence of Voice. This clitic is never used in CU complements selected by *fare*, while it is obligatory with *vedere*, when the embedded verb requires it (i.e. with inherently reflexive verbs) (as noted by Guasti 1993):

(45) a. L'= hai fatto {arrabbiare / *arrabbiar**si**}. (M: **4.86** vs. **1.07**; Mdn **5 vs. 1**)
him.CL have.2SG made get.angry get.angry-SE

b. L'= hai visto {*arrabbiare / arrabbiar**si**}. (M: **1.21** vs. **4.79**; Mdn: **1 vs. 5**)
him.CL have.2SG seen get.angry get.angry-SE

With the intransitive verb *arrabbiarsi* 'get angry', *si* is mandatory in all contexts, except when it is embedded in a causative construction (45a). This suggests that CUs embedded under *fare* are smaller than a VoiceP.[23]

A second argument comes from passivisable idioms, which we take to be vPs lacking a Voice specification. With *vedere*, idiomatic readings are accessible in both the FI and the FP. In the following examples more than 95% of participants who rated (46) as acceptable allowed the idiomatic meaning:[24]

(46) a. Maria ha visto prendere la medicina a sua figlia. (FI; M: **3.33**, Mdn: **3.5**)

Maria has seen take.INF the medicine to her daughter

(literal reading: **4%**; idiom: 72%; both possible: 24%)

b. Maria ha visto prendere la medicina da sua figlia. (FP; M: **3.52**, Mdn: **4**)

Maria has seen take.INF the medicine by her daughter

'Maria saw her daughter take/pick up the medicine'

(literal reading: **5%**; idiom: 55%; both possible: 41%)

This is expected if we consider that the complement of *vedere* is at least as large as VoiceP, as shown by the presence of the clitic *si* in (45b).

With *fare*, on the other hand, the idiomatic reading is only available with the FI, but not with the FP (47).[25]

(47) a. Maria ha fatto prendere la medicina a sua figlia. (FI; M: **4.91**, Mdn: **5**)

Maria has made take.INF the medicine to her daughter

'Maria had her daughter pick up/take the medicine'

(literal reading: **0%**; idiom: 52%; both possible: 48%)

b. Maria ha fatto prendere la medicina da sua figlia. (FP; M: **4.54**, Mdn: **5**)

Maria has made take.INF the medicine by her daughter

'Maria had her daughter pick up the medicine'

(literal reading: **82%**; idiom: 6%; both possible: 12%)

These results further suggest that the CU complement of *fare* is at least a vP when it is used in an FI, while it is smaller in FPs, blocking passivisable idioms.

Idioms which also contain a fixed subject yield similar results: the idiomatic reading is always preserved with *vedere*. With *fare*, it is only available when an FI is used; in FPs, it is ruled out (48).[26]

(48) Non è la prima volta che vedo fare i figli ciechi
not is the first time that see.1SG make the kittens blind
{alla / dalla} gatta frettolosa.
at-the by-the cat hasty
'It's not the first time that I see someone in a hurry make a mess of things.'

(49) Non sono io che ho fatto fare i figli ciechi
not am I that have.1SG made make the kittens blind
{alla / #dalla} gatta frettolosa.
at-the by-the cat hasty
'It's not me that made someone in a hurry make a mess of things.' (only available with FI; with FP only the literal reading is available)

In addition, data from control also show that CU complements of *fare* and of *vedere* are different. In the final clause in (50), the causee (i.e., Ugo) can control PRO when *vedere* is used, but not with *fare* (51):[27]

(50) a. La macchina, *pro*$_i$ l'= ho vista riparare {a/da} Ugo$_j$
the car 3FSG.ACC have.1SG seen repair.INF to/by Ugo

per PRO$_{i/j}$ partecipare alla corsa. (FI: M: **3.03**, Mdn: **3**)

to take.part.INF at.the race (FP: M: **4.24,** Mdn: **5**)

'I saw Ugo repair the car in order to take part in the race.'

(FI: Who took part at the race? me = 3%; **Ugo = 67%**; **either = 31%**)

(FP: Who took part at the race? me = 6%; **Ugo = 55%; either = 39%**)

(51) a. La macchina, *pro*$_i$ l'= ho fatta riparare {a/da} Ugo$_j$

the car 3SG.ACC have.1SG made repair.INF to Ugo

per PRO$_{i/*j}$ partecipare alla corsa. (FI: M: **4.45**, Mdn: **5**)

to take.part.INF at.the race (FP: M: **4.39**, Mdn: **5**)

'I made Ugo repair the car in order to take part in the race.'

(FI: Who took part at the race? **me = 69%;** Ugo = 3%; either = 28%)

(FP: Who took part at the race? **me = 71%;** Ugo = 0%; either = 29%)

If the causee is not overtly realized, the same picture obtains: an implicit causee can control PRO with *vedere* (52), but not with *fare* (53) (see Guasti 1993).[28]

(52) Ho visto rubare dei libri EC$_i$, PRO$_i$ nascondendo=li sotto il cappotto.

have.1SG seen steal.INF some books hiding=them.CL under the coat

'I have seen steal some books by hiding them under the coat.' (Guasti 1993:123)

(53) Il sindaco$_i$ ha fatto costruire il monumento {EC$_j$ / dall' architetto Nervi$_j$}

the mayor has made build.INF the monument by-the architect Nervi

per PRO$_{i/*j}$ ottenere appoggi politici. (Guasti 1993:100)

to receive.INF support political

'The mayor had the monument built (by the architect Nervi) to obtain political support.'

These results are unexpected: with both *fare* and *vedere* the causee is a projected argument of the clause in the FI and so is expected to be a potential controller. Therefore, the fact that it can always control PRO when the matrix verb is *vedere*, but never with *fare*, cannot be explained structurally, but is rather probably due to semantics, as suggested to us by Giampaolo Salvi (pers. comm.): with *fare*, the causer is directly involved (and affected) by the event, therefore she is seen as a prototypical controller. In the case of *vedere*, on the other hand, the person who perceives the embedded event is usually not part of it, so she might be a less natural controller than the perceivee, who is instead directly involved in the embedded event.

5.2.2 The structure of CU complements

In § 5.2.1, we have seen that CU complements of *fare* and *vedere* differ in relation to the presence of VoiceP: this projection is absent with *fare*, while it is present with *vedere*. In addition, the size of the complements of *fare* is different in FIs and FPs: FIs are vPs, since they allow the use of idioms, while FPs are VPs and do not allow idiomatic readings:

Table 5
CU complement sizes

	fare 'make'	*vedere* 'see'
FI	fare [$_{vP}$ …]	vedere [$_{VoiceP}$ ….]
FP	fare [$_{VP}$…]	vedere [$_{VoiceP}$ ….][29]

The different sizes of these CU complements explain why long passives are possible under *fare*, but not under *vedere*: the complements of *fare* are not full phases, since they are smaller than a VoiceP. Therefore, the promoted argument can move from the embedded vP/VP to the main Spec,TP, crossing just one phase. The complements of *vedere*, on the other hand, are VoicePs and thus they are phases: if one of their arguments moves to matrix Spec,TP it has to cross two phases in one step, violating PIC2.

Finally, let us consider the behaviour of unergative verbs under *fare*. Recall from §4.1.1 that some monovalent unergatives are compatible with long passivization whereas bivalent unergatives (which optionally take a PP complement) are not. While we will not offer a full explanation of this pattern here, it seems to suggest that case is not the only thing regulating passivization and that intervention of a second argument also plays a role. Transitive subjects in CU contexts resist passivization very strongly. This could be because they (a) lack accusative case in the active and/or (b) are not the closest DP to the matrix probe T. Bivalent unergatives, which bear accusative case in the active suggest that it is (b) which prevents them being promoted in passivizes, if we assume that they always include a covert PP argument. Assuming a smuggling approach to the FI (see Belletti 2017), VP movement to a position higher than the causee makes all internal arguments accessible to T. If bivalent unergatives always have a (potentially covert) PP argument, and this PP is closer to T (see Pineda and Sheehan 2023), then this will be sufficient to block long passivation of bivalent unergative subjects. A full technical implementation of this idea is beyond the scope of the present paper. What is relevant here is the finding that monovalent unergatives are clearly compatible with long passivization and the implications this has for previous accounts of this phenomenon.

5.3 Comparison with previous analyses of long passivization

Different kinds of analyses have been offered to explain restrictions on passivization of causative and perception verbs and space precludes a full discussion of them all, but here we briefly highlight some advantages of our phase-based explanation of the Italian facts.

Within the Cartographic approach to syntax, restrictions on long passives are taken to derive from the universal functional sequence (in which the Voice head is argued to dominate the Causative head; see Cinque 2003 but also Johnson 2014 for a different view). As noted by Cinque, in relation to Italian CU contexts, this captures the fact that both *fare* and *vedere* can be passivized (see above) but cannot themselves embed a passive:

(54) *Farò essere invitati tutti. (Cinque 2003:57)
make.1SG.FUT be invited everybody

(55) *Glie l'= ho vista esser presentata. (Cinque 2003:64)
3SG.DAT 3FSG.ACC have.1SG seen be introduced

Perception verbs are further argued to occupy a position immediately above causative and below Voice, based on the contrast in (67)-(68):

(56) Glie l'= ho vista far cadere.
3SG.DAT 3FSG.ACC have.1SG seen make.INF fall.INF
'I saw him make it fall/cause it to fall.'

(57) *Glie= l'= ho fatta veder cadere. (Cinque 2003:64)

3SG.DAT 3FSG.ACC have.1SG made see.INF fall.INF

A weakness of this approach which Cinque himself notes is that it fails to explain the more restricted passivization possibilities in other Romance languages such as French, European Portuguese and Spanish (as mentioned in Section 1). A further challenge, not discussed by Cinque, arises from the behaviour of *vedere*. As noted above, while *vedere* permits both CU and ECM complements in the active, long passivization is actually only possible with ECM complements. If like *fare*, *vedere* is located below voice then both verbs ought to allow long passives in CU contexts. An anonymous reviewer notes that while *vedere* does not allow for the passive auxiliary *essere* in its complement domain, it does allow for the passive auxiliaries *venire* 'come' and *andare* 'go':

(58) a. Non glie= l' ho mai vista venire presentata ufficialmente.

NEG 3SG.DAT.3FSG.ACC=have.1SG never seen.F be.INF presented.F officially

'I have never seen her being officially presented to him.'

b. Se l' è vista andare distrutta in un attimo.

REFL.CL 3FSG.ACC= is seen go.INF destroyed in an instant

'(S)he saw it being destroyed in an instant.'

As the reviewer notes, this would be consistent with the idea that while *fare* is located below voice, *vedere* is above it in CU contexts, hence the fact that only *fare* can passivize in CU contexts. Nonetheless, it is not clear how the Cartographic account can be extended to explain the contrast between *vedere* and *guardare* in ECM contexts, assuming they are biclausal. In such contexts, passive auxiliaries can be embedded under causative/perception verbs and one might expect the matrix verbs in question to be lexical rather than functional heads, in which case passivization should also be possible. This is the case with *vedere*, but with *guardare* we see a ban on passivization with ECM complements, as discussed above.

Guasti (1993) like us, attributes the different passivization patterns with *fare* and *vedere* to the different sizes of the complements that these verbs select. In her account, *fare* selects a VP complement (at least in the FP), while *vedere* mainly selects an AgrSP, as shown, among other things, by the possibility of having VP adverbs (like *completamente* 'completely') in the complements of *vedere* only. In addition, she notes the asymmetry discussed above concerning the clitic *si*. While our proposal is similar in spirit to Guasti's, it also differs in several crucial respects. Our proposal accounts for the fact that only the CU complements of *fare* permit long passivization as well as the fact that only the ECM complements of *vedere* and not *guardare* do. It is not clear how Guasti's (1993) account could be extended to these more intricate contrasts.

Finally, let us briefly review two different approaches to Italian long passives proposed by Folli and Harley in more recent work:

(i) Defective verb analysis (Folli and Harley 2007)

(ii) Voice/v bundling analysis (Folli and Harley 2013)

In relation to (i), Folli and Harley (2007) propose that in Italian it is possible to form long passives of the FP but not the FI. They present several kinds of evidence for this, notably the claim that while embedded unaccusative verbs freely allow passivization, unergative verbs do not, as discussed in Sections 2.4. The results of our corpus and AJT studies suggest, however, that only bivalent unergatives which can select a PP complement are incompatible with long passivization, and this split cannot easily be attributed to the FP/FI distinction. It therefore seems problematic to attribute passivizability to the defectivity of a matrix verb. It is also not clear to us how their approach could be extended to account for the patterns seen with *vedere* and *guardare*. As they note, *fare* can be considered defective as it disallows inflection with preceding direct objects, but the same is not true of *guardare* or *vedere* in CU contexts. In the absence of independent diagnostics for defectivity, the account risks circularity, despite its appeal when applied only to *fare*.

Modifying their earlier proposal, Folli and Harley (2013) propose a different account of Italian long passivation patterns. They claim that *fare* is a realization of v, and that Voice and v are bundled together in Italian, ruling out passives of light verbs on more principled grounds (and on a parameterised rather than language-specific basis). The prediction is that, in languages in which v and Voice are not bundled, passives of light verbs should be possible. To support their proposal, they provide evidence that light verbs do not passivize more generally in Italian:

(59) *?Una risata è stata fatta da Giulia. (active: Giulia ha fatto una risata)
a laughing is been made by Giulia (Giulia has made a laughing)

Despite its attractions, this account of Italian long passives also faces some challenges in the light of the data presented in Sections 3 and 4. First, as we have already noted, it seems clear that many unergative verbs permit long passivation under *fare*, calling into question the claim that the FI cannot be passivized. It is also unclear, moreover, how these accounts of *fare* long passives can be extended to perception verbs in Italian. As we have seen above, *guardare* never permits long passivization whereas *vedere* permits passivization of ECM but not CU complements. This might follow if *vedere* is a light verb in all CU contexts (unlike *fare*), but we would also have to assume *guardare* is a light verb, which seems wrong on both semantic and syntactic grounds. This kind of account is not impossible but in the absence of independent evidence for these bundling patterns, it does not seem very explanatory. In fact, it seems counter-intuitive. It would correctly capture the intuition that CU *vedere* is more grammaticalized than ECM *vedere*. However, it would also imply that CU *vedere* is more grammaticalized than CU *fare*, and that ECM *guardare* is more grammaticalized than ECM *vedere* and CU *fare*.

6 Conclusions

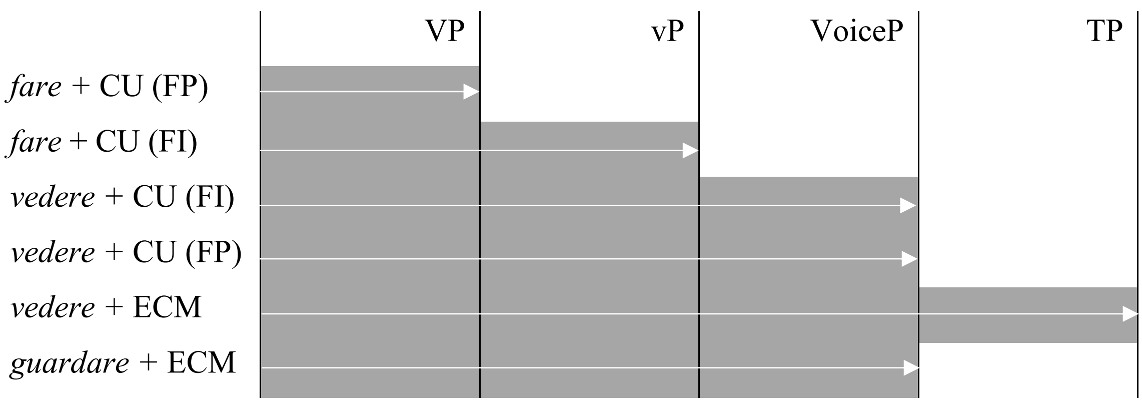
In this paper we have discussed the patterns of passivization with Italian causative and perception verbs. Italian is more permissive than other Romance languages, since it allows (under certain conditions) passivization of *fare* 'make' and *vedere* 'see', while passives of *guardare* 'watch' are ruled out. However, passives of *fare* are only possible when the promoted argument is either the internal argument (with unaccusative and transitive verbs), or the subject of a monovalent unergative verb. *Vedere* can be passivized when it takes an ECM complement (in this case the perceivee is promoted), but not when it takes a CU complement.

We have shown that the key to explaining the distribution of these long passives in Italian is the Phase Impenetrability Condition 2 (Chomsky 2001), according to which an item can only cross one phase-head at a time (see Sheehan and Cyrino 2024 on this restriction with English and Brazilian Portuguese causative and perception verbs). For Italian, we have discussed evidence showing that the complements of *fare* are VPs (in FIs) or vPs (in FPs): these are smaller than a phase, facilitating passivization. As far as unergative verbs are concerned, we have proposed the Unergative Hypothesis (38), a generalisation stating that the subject can be promoted when the unergative verb is monovalent; when it is bivalent, passivization is ruled out. This is due, we suggest, to intervention effects caused by the PP argument, even where it is not overtly realised.

In the case of perception verbs, we have argued that ECM complements of *vedere* are TPs: so, the perceivee can move to Spec,TP as an intermediate position on its way to the main clause. The complement of *guardare*, on the other hand, is a phasal VoiceP, and thus promotion of the perceivee would imply crossing two phase boundaries in one movement. This is also the case for the CU complements of *vedere*, which, as we have shown, are phasal VoicePs. Figure 7 resumes the different sizes of the complements of *fare*, *vedere* and *guardare.*

While we have offered a principled explanation of the passivization patterns of Italian causative and perception verbs, some questions remain. The first concerns the reasons why the ECM complements of the two perception verbs have different sizes: this is presumably due to the semantic differences between the complements of these two verbs, since *vedere* has a broader meaning, which allows also, among others, mental images (when we imagine something, including when we 'see' something that might happen in the future), reflection, and epistemic readings. Agentive *guardare* 'watch' disallows these readings. A second question concerns the internal make-up of bivalent unergatives: if their PP complement is always present, even if not overt, this might have wider consequences for the analysis of unergatives more generally. Finally, a remaining question relates to the passivization patterns of *lasciare*, which we could not discuss in this paper due to space limits, but which we will deal with in future work (Authors in prep.). This verb is more variable in its behaviour, for reasons that remain to be determined.

Figure 7: The size of the complements of causative and perception verbs



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[1] In addition, perception verbs take so-called Pseudo-relative clauses as complements in many Romance languages (see Kayne 1975, Cinque 1992, Casalicchio 2016, Casalicchio and Herbeck 2024, a.o.); in some languages, but crucially not in Italian, they also occur with gerunds or prepositional infinitives (see e.g. Raposo 1989 and Barbosa and Cochofel 2004 on prepositional infinitives in European Portuguese, Di Tullio 1998 on Spanish gerunds; Casalicchio 2019 proposes a contrastive analysis of these structures).

[2] In Italian, nouns are never marked for case; however, objects in the accusative occur as plain nouns, while dative case is marked through the use of the preposition *a*. Third-person clitic pronouns have different forms in the dative and accusative, so they can be used as further confirmation for the case used in CUs and ECMs (see also below).

[3] In Italian, the most common non-agentive verbs are *vedere* 'see' and *sentire*, which covers all the other senses ('hear, feel, taste, smell'). The now literary verbs *intendere* and *udire* (both 'hear') also belong to this group. Agentive verbs are more numerous, but the most frequent are *guardare* 'watch' and *ascoltare* 'listen to'.

[4] *Guardare* 'watch' seems to behave like other agentive verbs; in the case of non-agentive verbs, there are some differences between *vedere* 'see' and *sentire* 'hear etc.', as signalled by Guasti (1993:134-140). In particular, CU is more easily accepted with *sentire* than *vedere* in transitive contexts when the perceivee is a DP (rather than a clitic). In our AJTs, these contexts have a mean acceptability ranging from 2.97 to 4.24 with *vedere* (on a Likert scale from 1 to 5), and a median from 2.5 to 5; see (i) for an example:

(i) Il	guanciale,	l'=ho	visto	comprare	a	Nino	per	preparare	la	carbonara.
the	jowl	it=have.1SG	seen	buy	to	Nino	to	prepare	the	carbonara

'I have seen Nino buy the jowl to cook the carbonara.' (M: 3.45, Mdn: 3)

So, there is a slight transitivity 'penality' with CU under *vedere,* but such examples are not ungrammatical. We thank an anonymous reviewer for asking us to clarify this issue.

[5] Burzio (1986) claims that some speakers do allow passives promoting causees that are base generated as transitive subjects, but this must be a very marginal possibility given that we find no such examples.

[6] Folli and Harley actually mention that some verbs, like *lavorare* and (very marginally) *piangere*, are possible in long passives. An anonymous reviewer observes that (13) is different from (18), because in (13) the active counterpart is very marginal (??Gianni ha fatto telefonare Marco. 'Gianni made Marco call.'). Although we think that this sentence might be more acceptable if a specific context is given (in particular, if *fare* is interpreted as permissive), we would like to point out that this explanation is not available for other unergative verbs, which are perfectly fine in the active, but ungrammatical in the passive (e.g. *giocare* 'play', *pensare* 'think'), see § 4.

[7] An anonymous reviewer raises concerns over the use of statistical results from online acceptability judgement tests for syntactic research. We would agree, of course, that, ultimately, we are interested in I(ndividual)-languages and not population trends. Note, however, that the results of our study show relatively little variation across speakers regarding the acceptability of passives. In some cases, there are relevant sociolinguistic factors (as discussed in Appendix 5) but these have only a weak effect on the attested patterns. All in all, it seems to us that online acceptability judgements based on individual intuitions provide a useful tool to investigate I-language, coupled, of course, with traditional introspection (see also Sprouse, Schütze, and Almeida 2013).

[8] An anonymous reviewer notes that there are additional sematic restrictions on long object passives. We abstract away from these factors here but note that our AJT examples were based on attested corpus examples and so intended to be semantically plausible.

[9] Of the 40 unergative verbs attested in long passives of *fare* in the corpus (see Appendix 2), 38 are clearly monovalent in this sense, as confirmed by the DISC, one of

the main Italian dictionaries. Two, however, appear to be bivalent: *interagire* (2) 'interact', *reagire* (2) 'react'. These two verbs should be further investigated via an AJT but we do not take up this challenge here. The verb *parlare* 'talk' appears to permit long passivization despite allowing PP complements. It allows passivization when monovalent with the meaning 'spill the beans', while it is considerably worse when it has a PP complement (meaning 'talk about something'):

(i) Marco è stato fatto parlare (??di matematica).
Marco is been made talk of mathematics
'Marco was made to spill the beans/??Marco was caused to talk about mathematics.'

[10] An anonymous reviewer notes that the unergative verbs which permit long passives seem to have agentive subjects. This cannot be the deciding factor, however, as already noted, because *giocare* 'play' and *telefonare* 'telephone' are also agentive and yet incompatible with long passivization. The same reviewer notes, moreover, that, for them, *soffrire* 'suffer', which is non-agentive and also can occur with a PP complement, appears to marginally allow long passivization. This potential counterexample requires further empirical research.

[11] Because the response rate was much lower in phase 2, the number of responses here are smaller for: *ridere* 'laugh' (n=36) *telefonare* 'telephone' (n=32), *piangere* 'cry' (n=36), *correre* 'race' (n=36), *dormire* 'sleep' (n=32), *lavorare* 'work' (n=32) and *viaggiare* 'travel' (n=36), compared with *pensare* 'think'(n=229) and *giocare* 'play' (n=230) from phase 1.

[12] An anonymous reviewer observes that (30) is strongly degraded if the subject is 1st or 2nd person. We agree with this judgement, which we think holds for other cases as well. The differences between different persons need further investigation, which we plan to carry out in the future.

[13] An anonymous reviewer observes that, for them, there is no difference in the acceptability of *ridere* and *piangere*. We do not exclude that some speakers might share this judgement, but if we look at the sum of ratings given by our informants, the statistical analysis shows that there is a significant difference between these two verbs.

[14] See Appendix 4 for the full list of glossed example sentences.

[15] An anonymous reviewer notes that transitive verbs which can be used intransitively (*mangiare* 'eat', *tradire* 'betray', *bere* 'drink') also resist long passivization, further suggesting that semantic bivalence is indeed the relevant notion.

[16] Another potential factor was that this was the only of the unergative verbs which surfaced in an example containing the demoted causer as a by-phrase. This should be controlled for and/or investigated in any future study. An informal survey suggests to us that the presence/absence of the demoted causer does not affect acceptability.

[17] In Figure 2, the number of responses vary from 191 to 802 as follows: trans_obj (n=802 from 4 distinct examples); trans_subj (n=191 from a single example), unacc_subj (n=191 from a single example); unerg_subj (n=700 from 9 different examples). This is due to the different numbers of responses to different surveys coupled with the fact that we tested more unergative verbs due their variable behaviour and more transitive objects to test both FI and FP contexts (see Appendix 3 for the breakdown of individual verbs).

[18] An anonymous reviewer notes that they find long passives promoting the object of CU complements, grammatical:

(i)

Un	gesto	che	gli	è	stato	visto	fare	in	precedenza.
an	act	that	him.DAT	is	been	seen	do.INF	in	past

‘An act that he was previously seen doing.’

(ii)

Questo	è	stato	visto	fare	ripetutamente	dai	tuoi	studenti.
this	is	been	seen	do.INF	repeatedly	by-the	your	students

‘Your students were seen doing this repeatedly.’

We tested these sentences in a separate AJT: the first sentence was judged grammatical (mean 4.11, median 5), the second marginal (mean 2.96, median 3). However, when we looked at similar examples in the ItWac corpus, we found zero occurrences, and a Google search revealed fewer than 10 examples similar to (i); most of them concern the combination *veder fare* ‘see do’. If we also consider the judgements given to the examples in (35), we can conclude that *veder fare* is probably an exception, which is due either to the light verb nature of *fare*, or to the fact that *veder fare* has become a fixed, lexicalized expression.

[19] Sheehan and Cyrino note independent diagnostics for phasehood such as auxiliary distribution, VP-ellipsis and VP-fronting - see Harwood 2015, but also Ramchand and Svenonius 2014, Wurmbrand 2012, Boskovic 2014, Aelbrecht and Harwood 2015. See also Casalicchio and Herbeck 2024 for an extension of this analysis to Spanish perception verbs. As an anonymous reviewer notes, ‘to’ is possible in the active complements of perception verbs but not causatives; where present it gives rise to an inferential reading

involving indirect perception. See Sheehan and Cyrino (2024) for further discussion and the claim that 'make', 'hear' and 'see' (on a direct perception reading) are *wager* predicates.

[20] In a recent paper, Bryant, Kovač and Wurmbrand (2023) highlight cases where long passives are possible in the presence of embedded voice morphology. On the approach taken here, such cases would need to involve a larger TP complement feeding long A-movement.

[21] There is disagreement in the literature as to whether Italian has preverbal subject position connected to the EPP. Rizzi (1982) originally argued that it does, but Barbosa (1995) and Alexiadou and Anagnostopoulou (1998) famously proposed that Romance-style null subjects lack such a position. Alexiadou (2006) however recognises several differences between Italian and Spanish. Cardinaletti (2004) and Sheehan (2016) offer further evidence that Italian, in particular, does in fact have a preverbal subject position. We assume this position here.

[22] Tree for the following AJT example:

(i) Gianni **è stato visto rubare** una macchina da un poliziotto. (M: **3.61**, Mdn: **4**)
Gianni is been seen steal.INF a car by a policeman
'Gianni was seen stealing a car by a policeman.'

[23] As an anonymous reviewer notes, *si* related to inherent reflexives might be even lower than standard Voice. As far as causative constructions like (56a) are concerned, this would not change the picture: their complement is smaller than VoiceP. In addition, the reviewer notes that (56b) could be a case of ECM. This is certainly true, but note that

as CU is also an option with *vedere*, we would expect omission of *si* to also be possible if CU complements of *vedere* were identical to CU complements of *fare*. Note also that French causatives allow the clitic *se* attached to the infinitive, even where they take a CU complement (*il faisait se reveiller la fille* 'He made the girl wake up', Guasti 1993: 64). In addition, in Italian, examples can be created with *si* which are more clearly CU as they involve a dative causee:

(i)	(?)Gli	ho	visto	prendersi	dei	grossi	rischi.
	him.DAT	have.1SG	seen	take-SE	of-the	big	risks

'I saw him taking some big risks.'

A Google search has attested the use of *Gli ho visto* both with *prendersi* and with *farsi*.

[24] Examples (57a-b) are adapted from Guasti 1993. Participants were asked first to rate their acceptability and then to say what they mean, with the literal and idiomatic meanings paraphrased in Italian. Interpretations are only considered for those that rated the examples as 4/5 on the Likert scale.

[25] Similar results are obtained with other passivisable idioms, e.g. *gettare la spugna* 'throw in the towel' and *reggere il moccolo* 'be a third wheel', lit. "hold the snot" (judgements by the native speaker of this paper and colleagues). With non-passivisable idioms, on the other hand, the results are partly different: testing the idiom *tagliare la corda* 'flee' (lit. "cut the rope"), we observed that with all tested verbs (*fare*, *lasciare* and *vedere*) our informants accept the idiomatic reading when a FI is used, while less than half of them accept it when a FP is used (46% with *fare*, 44% with *vedere*, 21% with *lasciare*). This partly confirms Guasti's (1993:99) observation that the idiomatic reading

of non-passivisable idioms is not accessible in the FP. Since non-passivisable idioms obtain similar results with *fare*, *vedere* and *lasciare*, the unavailability of the idiomatic reading of these idioms in the FP seems not to be directly related to the structure, or its size. The analysis of the factors involved in the judgements of non-passivisable idioms is a matter for future research.

[26] These judgements come from one of the authors, and they were checked with other native speakers. The basic version of this idiom is:

(i) La gatta frettolosa fa i figli ciechi.
the cat hasty makes the kittens blind
'Someone in a hurry makes a mess of things.'

[27] Here too, participants were first asked to rate these sentences and then they were asked about their meaning. We present the meaning results only from those who rated the sentences as 4 or 5 on the five-point scale.

[28] Note that (52) is an instance of CU (not ECM), as shown by clitic climbing in (i):

(i) Li= ho visti rubare EC_i, PRO_i nascondendo=li sotto il cappotto.
3MPL.ACC have.1SG seen steal.INF hiding=3PLM.ACC under the coat
'I have seen them be stolen by hiding them inside a coat.'

Moreover, in an example parallel to (53) with a dative causee, this causee (*all'architetto Nervi*) also could not control PRO.

[29] Note that this implies that the causee is a projected argument with the FP under *vedere* but not under *fare*. This is supported by the fact that passivisable idioms are possible in FP contexts with *vedere* but not *fare*, as discussed in Section 5.2.2.